

Photographs by **HARDIK CHHABRA**

> **The harder it is to learn something, the more likely you'll remember it for longer periods of time.... If you get domain expertise, you'll be able to use these [AI] tools in a much more powerful way later on**
>
> **–Bharat N. Anand**, *Vice Provost for Advances in Learning, Harvard University; Henry R. Byers Professor of Business Administration, Harvard Business School*

FUNDAMENTALS COME FIRST

In an era of rapid technological advances, how should you approach the raft of Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools that are now available to carry out your tasks? Bharat N. Anand, Vice Provost for Advances in Learning at Harvard University, offers a simple thumb rule: the cost of errors and the time saved. For tasks that require precise information and where the cost of making a mistake is high, people will still be very careful about how they use Generative AI (GenAI). But for chores where GenAI can automate the mundane fairly well, the sheer amount of time saved will drive adoption.

The same logic applies to the field of education, Anand said at the India Today Conclave. At Harvard, for instance, an interview of faculty members who were using GenAI in their classrooms yielded some interesting examples: a faculty copilot chatbot that works like a teaching assistant available 24/7, and teachers saving time on designing tests and quizzes by refining the content that GenAI produces. Even an early experiment evaluating AI bot tutors against actual instructors in terms of students' learning outcomes suggested high engagement levels with the bots.

But will AI level the playing field in education, with everyone having access? Anand reckons there's a possibility it might go the opposite way, widening the digital divide, with benefits accruing disproportionately to those who already have domain expertise. "When you have knowledge of a subject and you start using ChatGPT, the way you interact with it, you are basically using your judgement to filter out what's useful and what's not," he explained. Therefore, Anand's advice to students is to study hard because domain knowledge will enable them to use AI tools more effectively. "And I would say to kids, follow the teachers who inspire you," he added. "And the reason is, if you can get inspired and passionate about a subject, that's going to build something that will last all your life...curiosity, which is intrinsic motivation." ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Cost of error and time savings will drive GenAI adoption; has potential for several-use cases in the classroom**
- **But it could widen the digital divide, with benefits accruing disproportionately to those with domain expertise**